WESTON: Because it was in my pocket. I found it there when I was looking for something to light my pipe. (*With meaning*) There were no spills.

LADY WESTON: No spills. What, again? Richard, you smoke far too much.

WESTON (*continuing hastily*) – It was slipped into my pocket by a man who brushed against me yesterday. A dark, lean fellow with an evil face.

LADY WESTON: I don't think he was very evil.

WESTON: What do you know about it? (*sinking into a chair*): Stop, Frances, stop! It upsets me to – (*Enter ROGER a little out of breath after his flying tour round the house.*)

WESTON: Ah, Roger. Have you seen to it all? Every door barred, every window shut, all workmen out –

ROGER (*a little embarrassed*): Every door except the kitchen one, my lord.

WESTON (*angry*): And why not the kitchen one?

ROGER (*stammering*): The cook seemed to think…. That is, she said…..

WESTON: Well, speak, man, what did she say, and how does what the cook thinks affect my order to bar the kitchen door?

ROGER (*in a rush*): The cook said she was a respectable woman and had never been behind bars in her life and she wasn't going to begin at her age, and she was quite capable of dealing with anyone who came to the kitchen door –

WESTON: Tell her to pack her things and leave the house at once.

LADY WESTON: And who will cook your pet dishes? I shall also see that all the downstairs windows are shuttered as you suggest. We can always haul the groceries through an upper window.

WESTON (*controlling himself*): I think that so frivolous a suggestion at so anxious a time is in poor taste, Frances, and unworthy of you –

LADY WESTON: Did it appear frivolous to you? How strange! I had thought it odd to shutter the walls and yet leave openings in the roof that one could drive a coach and horses through. However! (*She comes back into the room, takes two candelabra from different places in the room, and goes to the door*).

WESTON: What do you want with these?

LADY WESTON: If we are to be in darkness below we shall want all the candles we can gather. (*Exit.*)

WESTON: The aptness of the female mind to busy itself about irrelevant and inconsiderable **minutiae** is a source of endless wonder to me. (*Almost without noticing what he is doing he moves over to the fireplace and sticks his head into the chimney to view the width of it. As he withdraws it, he becomes aware of ROGER, standing watching).* I see no reason now why you should not resume your work, Roger.

ROGER: Oh, my lord, it is beyond my power to work while you are in danger. Is there not something I could do?

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